

FDI and Changing Dimensions of Ownership: Evidence from India, 2000–2026

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Abstract

Purpose: Foreign direct investment (FDI) changes who owns and controls a country's businesses, and its rules are written as limits on ownership. This study examines how FDI into India and the rules on foreign ownership changed between 2000 and 2026, and how employees of multinational companies perceive FDI's effects. **Methods:** The study combines official data on gross and net FDI, source countries and sectors from April 2000 to March 2026; a review of sectoral ownership limits and their changes since 1991; and a survey of 100 employees of multinational companies in India, analysed with Wilson intervals, sign tests with Holm adjustment and Fréchet bounds on joint agreement. **Results:** Gross FDI inflows reached a record US\$94.8 billion in 2025-26, but repatriation by foreign investors (US\$53.6 billion) and outward investment by Indian firms (US\$33.3 billion) left net FDI of US\$7.7 billion, after it fell to US\$1.0 billion in 2024-25. Ownership limits rose almost without exception, with insurance moving from 26% to 100%, while a 2020 rule made approval depend on the investor's country of origin. About two-thirds of survey respondents agreed with each benefit of FDI and about two-thirds with each concern; at least 46% agreed both that FDI makes domestic industry more competitive and that it displaces local businesses. **Conclusion:** Gross inflows overstate the change in foreign ownership. Ownership now turns over faster, moves back to domestic investors through stock-market sales, and is regulated by who the investor is as well as how much they own.

Keywords: Foreign direct investment, Ownership structure, Net FDI, Repatriation, Sectoral caps, Press Note 3, India

JEL Classification: F21 , F23 , G32 , O53

1 Introduction

Foreign direct investment (FDI) is investment by which a foreign company or fund takes a lasting interest in a business, conventionally 10% or more of its equity. Unlike portfolio investment, which only buys shares, FDI changes who owns and controls companies. For that reason its rules are written as limits on ownership: how much of a sector foreigners may own, whether they need approval, and, since 2020, which countries they may come from.

A foreign company can enter a country by greenfield investment, building a new business under its own ownership; by a joint venture, sharing ownership with a local partner; or by acquisition, buying an existing company in part or in full. Each gives the investor a different degree of control and changes the ownership of the host country's industry in a different way. For much of the period after independence, India kept foreign ownership low: companies with more than 40% foreign equity were restricted under the Foreign Exchange Regulation Act of 1973. The New Industrial Policy of 1991 allowed automatic approval of up to 51% foreign ownership in 34 priority industries, and since 2000 most sectors have been open under an automatic route that needs only notification to the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), with the rest requiring government approval and a short list closed altogether. The Foreign Investment Promotion Board, which approved investments case by case, was abolished in 2017.

Three developments have since changed what FDI means for ownership. Private equity, sovereign wealth and pension funds now account for a large share of FDI, and they buy stakes to sell later. Foreign parents have begun to sell stakes in Indian subsidiaries on the Indian stock market, as Hyundai Motor India (INR 278.7 billion, October 2024) and LG Electronics India (INR 116 billion, October 2025) did through pure offers for sale ([Business Standard, 2026a](#)). And Indian companies have become foreign owners themselves.

Most discussion of FDI in India focuses on gross inflows, which have risen almost every year. This paper asks how the volume, sources and destinations of FDI into India have changed since 2000; how the limits on foreign ownership have changed; and how people working inside multinational companies see FDI's effect on domestic ownership and industry. It contributes by documenting the widening gap between gross and net FDI since 2023, by tracing the shift from sectoral limits to restrictions based on the investor's origin, and by analysing a survey whose respondents endorse both the benefits and the costs of FDI.

2 Literature review

2.1 Why firms invest abroad

[Hymer \(1976\)](#) argued that a foreign firm starts at a disadvantage against local competitors, so it invests abroad only when it has an advantage of its own, such as technology, a brand or scale, large enough to overcome that handicap; FDI is therefore about control, not just capital. [Dunning \(2000\)](#) built this into the eclectic or OLI paradigm, in which a firm invests abroad when ownership advantages, location advantages and internalisation advantages come together. Dunning's investment development path ([Dunning,](#)

1981) links a country’s net FDI position to its stage of development: as domestic firms build their own ownership advantages, outward investment rises and net FDI moves towards zero. Buckley and Casson (2009), reviewing thirty years of internalisation theory, emphasised that the choice between owning and contracting depends on the costs of transacting in imperfect markets for knowledge, and Caves (1996) showed how host-country ownership limits push foreign firms into joint ventures they would not otherwise choose.

2.2 Ownership structure and the host country

Meyer et al (2011) describe multinationals as embedded both in their global network and in each local context, so that the ownership form they choose reflects how much they need local partners’ knowledge and legitimacy. Cantwell and Mudambi (2005) show that some subsidiaries create new competences rather than only using the parent’s, making technology transfer more likely when subsidiaries are given research mandates. Rugman and Verbeke (2004) found that most large multinationals earn most of their sales in their home region, qualifying the idea that FDI makes ownership borderless.

2.3 Emerging-market multinationals, institutions and distribution

Ramamurti (2012) argued that multinationals from emerging markets such as India compete on cost, on the ability to operate in difficult institutional environments and on acquisitions that buy technology and brands abroad, and Contractor et al (2007) found an S-shaped relationship between international expansion and performance among Indian firms. Cuervo-Cazurra (2006) showed that host-country corruption deters FDI, especially from countries that have signed the OECD Anti-Bribery Convention. Helpman (2018) finds that trade and FDI have raised inequality within countries, but by less than is often assumed. UNCTAD (2020) documented the collapse of global FDI in the pandemic and the spread of investment screening, of which India’s 2020 rule on neighbouring countries is one example.

Most studies of FDI in India measure gross inflows and their links with growth, productivity and exports. The gap between gross and net FDI, large only since 2023, and restrictions based on the investor’s country of origin, introduced in 2020, have received little attention; this paper addresses both.

3 Data and methods

3.1 Secondary data

Financial-year inflows from 2000-01 and cumulative inflows by country and sector are from the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) fact-sheet to June 2025 (Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade, 2025). Inflows by country and sector for 2025-26 are from DPIIT data as reported by India Briefing (2026), and total inflows for 2025-26 from the Ministry of Finance (India Tribune, 2026). Gross inflows, repatriation, outward investment and net FDI are from

RBI data as reported by [Business Standard \(2024, 2025, 2026b\)](#). Ownership limits come from DPIIT’s consolidated FDI policy and later press notes ([Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade, 2020](#)), the insurance amendment of 2025 ([Press Information Bureau, 2025](#)), the space policy of 2024 and the Cabinet decision of 10 March 2026 ([All India Radio News, 2026](#)), cross-checked against [Beacon Filing \(2026\)](#).

3.2 Survey

A structured questionnaire of 14 closed statements was answered on a five-point Likert scale (5 strongly agree to 1 strongly disagree) by 100 employees of multinational companies in India at associate, supervisory and higher levels, chosen by convenience sampling. Eight statements describe benefits of FDI, five describe concerns and one asks whether policy should favour attracting FDI over protecting domestic industry (Appendix A).

For each statement, the share agreeing (agree or strongly agree) is reported with a 95% Wilson interval, together with the share disagreeing and the mean score. A two-sided exact sign test compares agreeing with disagreeing answers, leaving out neutral answers, and the p -values are adjusted for 14 tests by Holm’s method. Only the count of answers for each statement was retained, not each respondent’s full set of answers, so answers cannot be correlated across statements. Instead the analysis reports the Fréchet lower bound on the share of respondents who agreed with two statements i and j at once:

$$\Pr(A_i \cap A_j) \geq \max\{0, \Pr(A_i) + \Pr(A_j) - 1\}, \quad (1)$$

where A_i is the event of agreeing with statement i .

4 Results

4.1 Inflows since 2000

FDI into India has grown in four phases (Figure 1): total inflows below US\$10 billion a year until 2005-06; a jump to US\$41.9 billion by 2008-09, following the opening of construction, telecom and retail; a plateau of US\$34–47 billion until 2013-14; and steady growth from 2014-15 to US\$84.8 billion in 2021-22, a dip to about US\$71 billion in 2022-24 as global interest rates rose, and a record US\$94.8 billion in 2025-26, 18% more than the year before and 23 times the 2000-01 level ([Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade, 2025](#); [India Tribune, 2026](#)). In 2025-26, 62% of inflows were new equity (US\$58.9 billion) and 38% reinvested earnings and other capital: money foreign-owned companies earned in India and kept there, which raises foreign ownership without new foreign money arriving.

4.2 Sources and destinations

From April 2000 to June 2025, Mauritius (24.4%) and Singapore (24.0%) together supplied almost half of equity inflows, followed by the United States (10.2%), the Netherlands (7.2%) and Japan (6.0%) ([Department for Promotion of Industry and](#)

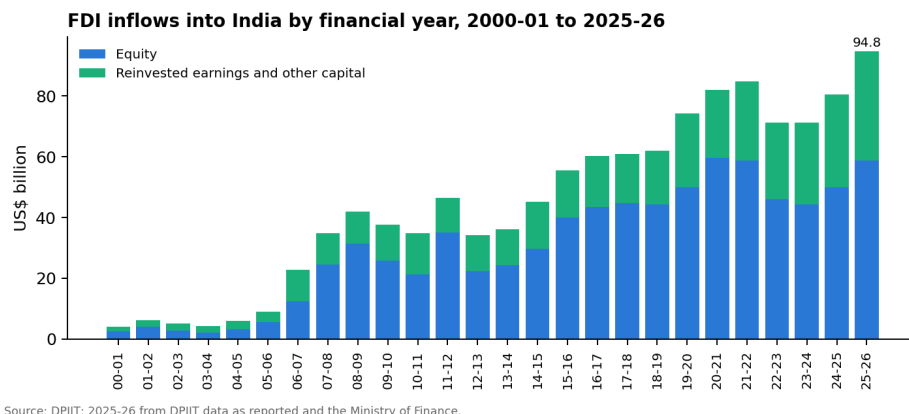


Fig. 1 FDI inflows into India by financial year, 2000-01 to 2025-26. Sources: [Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade \(2025\)](#); 2025-26 from [India Briefing \(2026\)](#) and [India Tribune \(2026\)](#)

[Internal Trade, 2025](#)). Mauritius and Singapore are mostly conduits: their tax treaties with India made them the natural base for global funds. After the treaties were amended in 2016 to let India tax capital gains on shares bought from April 2017, Mauritius's lead faded; in 2025-26 Singapore supplied 34% of equity inflows and Mauritius 11%, while direct investment from the United States doubled from US\$5.5 billion to US\$11.2 billion ([India Briefing, 2026](#)). Because of this routing, the ultimate owners behind much of India's FDI are not visible in the country data.

Since 2000, services (16.3%) and computer software and hardware (15.5%) have received almost a third of equity inflows ([Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade, 2025](#)). In 2025-26, software and hardware became the largest destination, at US\$13.9 billion (24% of equity), and Maharashtra and Karnataka together received more than half of equity inflows ([India Briefing, 2026](#)).

4.3 Changes in ownership limits

Table 1 traces the main changes. Three patterns stand out. First, the direction has been almost entirely one way: the only new sectoral cap in the period was on digital news media, set at 26% in 2019, and insurance shows the typical path of a low initial cap raised step by step (26% in 2000, 49% in 2015, 74% in 2021 and 100% in 2025 ([Press Information Bureau, 2025](#))). Second, caps have become tiered, with foreign ownership automatic up to one threshold and subject to approval above it, as in defence (74% and 100%), private banks (49% and 74%) and launch vehicles (49% and 100%). Third, a few sectors remain protected: news media (26% for print and digital, 49% for television) and multi-brand retail (51%, with approval).

The most important change since 2020 is a new dimension of ownership. Press Note 3 of April 2020 made the investor's country of origin, not the sector, the basis for approval: any investment from a country sharing a land border with India, in practice mainly China, needs government approval, and the rule applies to the beneficial owner

Table 1 Main changes in India’s limits on foreign ownership, 1991–2026

Year	Sector	Change
1991	All industries	Automatic approval up to 51% in 34 priority industries
2000	All industries	Automatic route becomes the default; insurance opened at 26%
2012	Retail	Single-brand retail to 100%; multi-brand retail opened at 51% with approval
2014	Defence, railways	Defence from 26% to 49%; railway infrastructure 100% automatic
2015	Insurance	26% to 49%
2016	Defence, aviation, e-commerce	Defence above 49% with approval; scheduled airlines 49% automatic and 100% with approval; e-commerce marketplaces 100%
2017	All industries	Foreign Investment Promotion Board abolished
2018	Single-brand retail	100% automatic
2019	Coal, contract manufacturing, digital media	Coal and contract manufacturing 100% automatic; digital news media capped at 26%
2020	Land-border countries	All investment needs government approval (Press Note 3)
2020	Defence	Automatic route from 49% to 74%
2021	Insurance, telecom	Insurance 49% to 74%; telecom 100% automatic
2024	Space	Satellites 74% automatic; launch vehicles 49% automatic; components 100% automatic
2025	Insurance	74% to 100% (Act passed 17 December 2025)
2026	Land-border countries	60-day deadline for approval decisions (10 March 2026)

Sources: [Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade \(2020\)](#), [Press Information Bureau \(2025\)](#), [All India Radio News \(2026\)](#), [Beacon Filing \(2026\)](#).

rather than the immediate investor. In March 2026 the government kept the screening but set a 60-day deadline for decisions ([All India Radio News, 2026](#)).

4.4 Gross versus net FDI

Between 2022-23 and 2025-26, gross inflows rose by a third, but repatriation by foreign investors rose 83% and outward investment by Indian companies more than doubled (Table 2, Figure 2). Foreign investors took out 41% of what came in during 2022-23 and 57% in 2025-26. Net FDI fell from US\$28.0 billion to US\$1.0 billion in 2024-25, the lowest in at least two decades, before recovering to US\$7.7 billion. Much of the repatriation reflects foreign owners selling stakes built up in earlier years: private equity funds exiting through sales to strategic buyers, and foreign parents selling part of their Indian subsidiaries on the stock market. When a parent sells shares to Indian investors, ownership moves from foreign to domestic hands while the company continues to operate in India; the RBI has described this as the sign of a mature market that investors can enter and leave easily ([Business Standard, 2025](#)). The rise in outward investment is consistent with the later stages of Dunning’s investment development path. Gross FDI therefore overstates the change in foreign ownership.

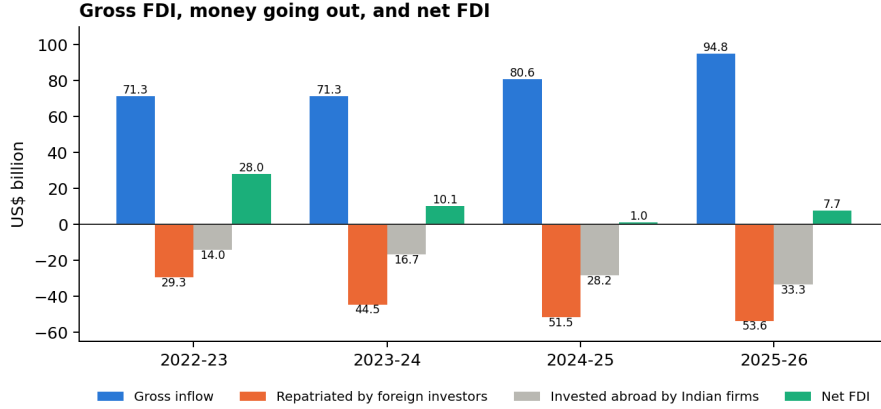
4.5 Survey findings

Agreement exceeded disagreement for every statement (Table 3, Figure 3; sign test, Holm-adjusted $p \leq 0.003$). Respondents agreed with the benefits and the concerns in equal measure: across the eight benefit statements an average of 67% agreed, and across the five concern statements also 67%. The most agreed-with benefit, that FDI encourages partnerships (75%), was matched exactly by the most agreed-with concern, that FDI displaces local businesses (75%).

Table 2 Gross FDI, money going out and net FDI (US\$billion)

	2022-23	2023-24	2024-25	2025-26
Gross FDI inflow	71.3	71.3	80.6	94.8
Repatriated by foreign investors	29.3	44.5	51.5	53.6
Invested abroad by Indian firms	14.0	16.7	28.2	33.3
Net FDI	28.0	10.1	1.0	7.7

Source: RBI data reported by [Business Standard \(2024, 2025, 2026b\)](#). Figures are revised between releases, so items may not add exactly.



Source: RBI data as reported by Business Standard.

Fig. 2 Gross FDI, repatriation, outward FDI and net FDI, 2022-23 to 2025-26

By Eq. (1), at least 46% of respondents agreed both that FDI makes domestic industry more competitive (Q1) and that it displaces local businesses (Q9), and at least 50% agreed both that it encourages partnerships (Q10) and that it displaces local businesses; every one of the 40 benefit–concern pairs has a lower bound of at least 20%. These positions are not contradictory, since competition from foreign firms can strengthen an industry while pushing its weaker firms out, but they show that people working inside multinationals do not see FDI as simply good or bad. Views on ownership were likewise mixed: 71% agreed that FDI diversifies ownership and 67% that it concentrates ownership in a few multinationals, both of which can hold in different sectors. Two-thirds favoured attracting FDI over protecting domestic industry, consistent with the direction of policy. The weakest agreement concerned resilience (59%) and sovereignty (61%), the most abstract statements and the ones with the most disagreement.

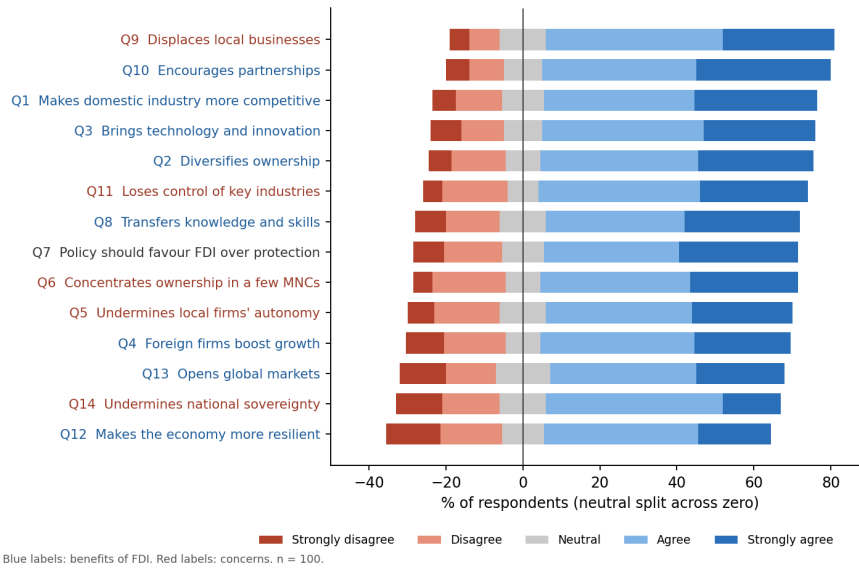
5 Discussion

The results show three ways in which the dimensions of ownership have changed that headline inflows do not reveal. Ownership now turns over: more than half of gross inflows in 2025-26 was offset by repatriation. Foreign owners sell to Indian investors through the stock market, moving ownership back to domestic hands without closing

Table 3 Survey answers ($n = 100$)

	Statement (short form; full wording in Appendix A)	Agree	95% interval	Disagree	Mean
Q10	Encourages partnerships	75%	66–82%	15%	3.89
Q9	Displaces local businesses	75%	66–82%	13%	3.86
Q1	Makes domestic industry more competitive	71%	61–79%	18%	3.79
Q2	Diversifies ownership	71%	61–79%	20%	3.75
Q3	Brings technology and innovation	71%	61–79%	19%	3.73
Q11	Loses control of key industries	70%	60–78%	22%	3.71
Q6	Concentrates ownership in a few multinationals	67%	57–75%	24%	3.66
Q7	Policy should favour FDI over protection	66%	56–75%	23%	3.66
Q8	Transfers knowledge and skills	66%	56–75%	22%	3.66
Q4	Foreign firms boost growth	65%	55–74%	26%	3.54
Q5	Undermines local firms' autonomy	64%	54–73%	24%	3.59
Q13	Opens global markets	61%	51–70%	25%	3.47
Q14	Undermines national sovereignty	61%	51–70%	27%	3.37
Q12	Makes the economy more resilient	59%	49–68%	30%	3.34

Agree: agree or strongly agree, with a 95% Wilson interval. Mean on a scale of 1 (strongly disagree) to 5 (strongly agree).

Most respondents agreed with the benefits and the concerns alike**Fig. 3** Answers to the 14 statements, ordered by net agreement; benefits in blue labels, concerns in red

any business. And who the owner is now matters as much as how much they own. The survey reflects this complexity: respondents recognised competition, technology and partnership as benefits while also agreeing that FDI displaces local firms and concentrates control.

For policymakers, the findings suggest tracking net FDI and ownership rather than gross inflows alone, by publishing repatriation and outward investment by sector and country with the quarterly inflow data; keeping liberalisation predictable, as the

stepwise opening of insurance has been; applying origin-based screening quickly and transparently, keeping to the 60-day deadline and publishing approval and rejection counts; improving disclosure of ultimate owners, since nearly half of FDI is routed through Mauritius and Singapore; and reviewing the remaining protected sectors on explicit criteria. For businesses, tiered limits make joint ventures and minority stakes the practical route into defence, banking, space and media, and for Indian firms partnerships with foreign investors are the main channel for technology and market access, with control a matter of how the partnership is structured.

The study has limitations. The survey is small, drawn by convenience and limited to employees of multinationals, who may view FDI more favourably than others. Every statement was worded so that agreeing meant holding the stated view, and agreement ranged only from 59% to 75%, so part of the pattern may reflect acquiescence; because only answer counts were retained, genuine ambivalence cannot be separated from acquiescence. Country and sector data for 2025-26 come from reports of DPIIT data and may be revised, net FDI figures are revised between releases, and the ownership limits are summarised: many sectors carry further conditions. Future research should collect respondent-level data with reverse-worded statements and a sample including domestic firms, study the effect of foreign-parent share sales on the governance and performance of Indian subsidiaries, and measure how much of India's FDI is ultimately owned by residents of third countries or of India itself.

6 Conclusion

In the quarter-century since 2000, FDI into India has grown from US\$4 billion a year to a record US\$94.8 billion, and the rules on foreign ownership have opened sector by sector, almost always in one direction. Yet gross inflows overstate the change in foreign ownership: repatriation and outward investment have risen faster, net FDI has fallen to a fraction of gross inflows, and since 2020 the investor's origin has become a dimension of ownership in its own right. FDI is therefore not simply a matter of attracting more foreign capital. It changes who owns the economy, and that change needs to be measured and managed.

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Declarations

- **Funding:** No funding was received for this study.
- **Competing interests:** The author has no competing interests to declare.
- **Ethics approval and consent to participate:** Participation in the survey was voluntary, and only aggregate answer counts were retained; no personal identifying information is reported.
- **Data availability:** All data used in this study, including the survey answer counts, are available at <https://github.com/harsh-github007/FDI-and-Changing-Dimensions-of-Ownership>.

- **Code availability:** The survey analysis and figure scripts are available in the same repository, and the data can be explored at <https://harsh-github007.github.io/FDI-and-Changing-Dimensions-of-Ownership/>.
- **Author contributions:** Harsh Raj designed the study, collected and analysed the data and wrote the manuscript.

Appendix A Questionnaire

Respondents rated each statement from 5 (strongly agree) to 1 (strongly disagree).

1. FDI enhances the competitiveness of domestic industries.
2. FDI leads to a more diversified ownership structure in domestic markets.
3. FDI contributes to technological advancements and innovation in domestic industries.
4. The involvement of foreign-owned companies in domestic markets positively impacts overall economic growth.
5. FDI undermines the autonomy of local businesses.
6. FDI leads to the concentration of ownership in the hands of a few multinational corporations.
7. Government policies should prioritize attracting FDI over protecting domestic industries.
8. FDI fosters knowledge transfer and skill development within domestic workforce.
9. The rise of FDI results in the displacement of local businesses.
10. FDI encourages collaboration and partnership between domestic and foreign entities.
11. FDI leads to a loss of control over key industries within a country.
12. FDI promotes economic diversification and resilience in domestic markets.
13. FDI facilitates access to global markets for domestic businesses.
14. FDI undermines national sovereignty by allowing foreign entities to exert influence over local economies.

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